

The Ferryman Game Design and Prototype Workbook

Editable examples and templates for the whole game

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The next task is to test a complete crossing, then a short run, and use what happens to decide the larger game. This workbook covers the concept, destinations, rules, content, presentation, digital systems, and playtesting. Completed examples provide something concrete to try. Blank templates let the team replace those examples and extend the design.

Decision authority: The team owns the final experience, destination rules, morality, progression, ending, platform, engine, art direction, and production scope. Using an example in a test does not approve it for the final game.

A complete paper trial, a library of optional mechanics, and working sheets for the team to make the game its own.

Source concepts, trial rules, team decisions, and future test results are labeled separately throughout.

Quick summary

The game: Play Charon. Choose who fits in a four-seat boat and where to take them. Paying souls support the service. Souls also leave memories that affect later crossings. Those left waiting can become wraiths. The destination system is a new idea to test alongside the report's core loop.

The central choice: Compare money, relationships, future memories, destination, and the cost of refusal. The design aims to make these considerations compete. Playtesting must establish whether they do.

A crossing: Refill shore, recall memories, choose route and passengers, resolve pressure, collect rewards, pay any quota, advance refusal, and clean up.

Playable example: Six crossings. Start with two obols and three Standing. Refill to five souls. Carry at most four seats. Play at most one residue for one Standing. Pay three obols after crossings three and six. Three refusals create a wraith. Failure occurs if pressure exceeds Standing or a quota cannot be paid.

Three trial routes: Elysium costs one obol and has zero base pressure. Asphodel is free and has one pressure. Tartarus is free and has two pressure, with one service obol on a nonempty arrival. These settings test a tradeoff; they do not define a soul's moral worth.

Greek myth directions: Explore divine judgments, guides, gates, oaths, memory, and seasonal passage. Source notes and distinct gameplay adaptations appear in section 20.

Team choices still open: Charon's authority, soul wishes, final route rules, the meaning of Standing, deck management, failure and endings, progression, platform, engine, and presentation.

Next checkpoint: Prepare the coming week's paper-prototype showcase using section 17A. Confirm the date and demo length, prepare the kit, rehearse, and complete checkpoint C01 before presenting.

Start here: Make the twelve soul slips and residue cards in sections 9 and 10. Follow sections 6 to 8. Record one run using section 18. Treat every added rule as provisional until the team reviews the evidence.

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1 How to use this workbook

REPORT identifies concepts in the supplied report. **USER IDEA** identifies the additional destination concept. **TRIAL** identifies a proposed rule or example that can be changed. **TEAM DECISION** identifies an unresolved choice. **RESULT** is reserved for observations after testing.

All invented numbers in TRIAL sections are starting settings, not balance findings. All soul stories, destination identities, and new mechanics below are design examples. The proposed underworld is a fictional adaptation; these pages do not establish mythology as historical fact.

A practical starting session

1. Read sections 2 to 5 together. Choose a temporary player aim and routing model.
2. Use sections 6 to 10 to make a small paper kit and run the six-crossing trial.
3. Record decisions and confusion using section 18. Change one rule family at a time.
4. Duplicate the templates in sections 9 to 17 as the design grows.
5. Approve a digital scope only after the paper rules work without improvised rulings.

Workbook map

Sections	Use
2 to 3	Source baseline and the experience to test
4 to 5	Team decisions and destination exploration
6 to 8	Playable trial setup, procedure, and worked example
9 to 11	Soul, residue, destination, and event examples and templates
12 to 13	Systems, economy, progression, and narrative
14 to 16	Interface, presentation, and digital handoff
17 and 17A	Prototype stages and coming-week showcase checkpoint
18	Playtesting
19 to 22	Optional mechanics, Greek myth, decisions, and sources

Working fields: Design owner [name] · Rules owner [name] · Content owner [name] · Next test [date] · Current rules version [version] · Current question [one sentence].

2 What the current concept establishes

The report proposes a single-player game about choosing which souls Charon ferries under a permanent capacity constraint. A crossing is the repeating unit. Delivered souls leave residue in a deck, and souls left waiting can become wraiths. [R, p. 1]

REPORT concept	Source	Treatment in this workbook
Charon carries souls; the dead keep arriving	R p. 1	Starting premise; the team's final narrative stance remains open
Shore, Load, Cross, Arrive, and shore decay	R p. 1	Preserved, with explicit timing added for testing
Relationships, separate currencies, and consequences across crossings	R pp. 2 to 3	Core hypotheses to test
Hidden values, random resolution, and changing capacity deferred	R pp. 2 to 3	Kept out of the initial trial
Four seats; soul costs of one or two seats	R pp. 3 to 4	Used as trial starting settings
About five souls shown; third refusal creates a wraith	R pp. 1 and 3	Used with a precise refill and timing rule
About twenty soul cards and eight event cards	R pp. 3 to 4	Source estimates; the smaller trial uses twelve souls
Ending, deck clutter, wraith severity, and quota escalation unresolved	R p. 4	Explicit team decisions
Multiple destinations with prices or event access	U1	Explored in sections 5 and 11

Gaps that need a rule before testing

The report includes an event draw in the loop and an event-card inventory, but defers stochastic resolution. It describes loading as the main decision while leaving residue use unspecified. Standing is named but has no complete gain, spending, or loss procedure. Wraith actions and the quota amount are also undefined. [R, pp. 1 to 4]

The trial resolves these gaps temporarily: all river information is visible, route and residue choices happen during Load, and exact resource and wraith rules appear below. These are additions for testing.

Design hypotheses rather than findings

Relationships, resource conflict, and delayed consequences may make players consider more than the immediate fare. The report argues for this direction; it does not supply playtest measurements. [R, pp. 2 to 3] Test whether players actually change priorities and explain tradeoffs. Do not describe the design as proven to prevent an optimal strategy.

TEAM DECISION: What should remain from the current concept? [retain] What may change? [revise] What evidence would justify a change? [observation].

3 Experience and concept template

Completed concept example

TRIAL pitch: As Charon, choose which souls share a limited boat and where the crossing takes them. Payment keeps the service running; relationships and remembered lives shape later choices. Every departure also decides who waits.

Proposed primary experience: Thoughtful responsibility under visible pressure. The player should understand the immediate cost while remaining uncertain about what choice they personally prefer.

Proposed play pattern: Inspect souls and routes, compare two plausible loads, commit, observe consequences, and reconsider on the next shore. A run should produce a history worth discussing, even when a resource objective is missed.

Proposed pillar	Supporting mechanic	Evidence to seek
Every seat matters	Fixed capacity and varied seat costs	Tester explains whom an extra seat would help
Souls remain individuals	Named links, short requests, recorded delivery history	Tester recalls a specific soul without prompting
Choices echo forward	Residue and refusal counters	A previous choice changes a later load
Passage has a destination	Route costs and different pressures	Tester weighs destination against another constraint

These are proposed criteria, not results. A team may prefer strategic mastery, narrative discovery, or survival tension as the primary experience.

Copy and complete

Working title: [title]

Player role and authority: [who the player is; what they may decide]

One-sentence pitch: [role] chooses [action] under [constraint] to pursue [aim].

Primary feeling: [one priority] · **Secondary feeling:** [one supporting priority]

Main verbs: [inspect, choose, arrange, remember, or alternatives]

Primary audience and context: [audience] · **Target session:** [duration to test]

Three pillars: [pillar / mechanic / observable evidence] for each.

Boundaries: [features that do not support this version]

Experience failure: [what would make the game miss its intended feeling]

Owner / decision date / next evidence: [name / date / test].

4 Major decisions reserved for the team

Choose a temporary answer where a test needs one. Keep the final decision marked open until the team has enough evidence. Suggested options below are alternatives, not a requirement to choose from a fixed menu.

ID and decision	Options and tradeoffs	Trial assumption	Decide by
D01 Primary experience	Responsibility emphasizes consequence; mastery emphasizes planning; survival emphasizes pressure	Responsibility with visible costs	First test
D02 Charon's authority	Carrier follows judgments; guide negotiates requests; judge assigns destinations	Route access unrestricted for mechanical testing	Before narrative approval
D03 Routing structure	One stop is compact; multiple stops add itinerary planning; conditional access creates windows	One destination per boat	First route test
D04 Standing	Spendable resolve is explicit; persistent reputation changes thresholds; deck-derived Standing reduces a separate track	Spendable crossing resilience and residue cost	First complete loop
D05 Residue	Drawn hand supports deck identity; tableau exposes history; active set plus archive limits clutter	Deterministic queue, hand of two, one play	First complete loop
D06 Ending and failure	Fixed run gives closure; endless duty needs a stopping ritual; scoring makes comparison easy but may narrow values	Six crossings; pressure or quota can end early	First run test
D07 Wraiths and recovery	Persistent pressure creates urgency; one-time harm is simpler; appeasement offers repair	Persistent pressure, no removal	First run test
D08 Shore arrivals	Refill to a target is compact; fixed arrivals create a crowd; capped queue needs overflow rules	Refill to five from fixed supply	First complete loop
D09 River information	Fixed visible conditions isolate rules; previewed draws add variability; hidden draws add surprise	No random events	Before event test
D10 Soul wishes	Requests may be binding, advisory, or negotiable; mismatch may alter story or rules	Flavor only; no mismatch penalty	Before route narrative test

ID and decision	Options and tradeoffs	Trial assumption	Decide by
D11 Progression and forgetting	Lateral memories preserve constraint; upgrades offer growth; forgetting can be permanent or archival	No upgrades, culling, or metaprogression	Before expanded run
D12 Production scope	Platform, engine, controls, art, audio, and available effort determine feasible breadth	Paper first; all digital choices open	Before digital build

Also assign: Quota amount and escalation belong to D06; prices and event access belong to D03; treatment of souls and mythology belong to D02 and D10. These choices can be split into separate records when discussion needs more detail.

Decision record template: ID [] · Question [] · Owner [] · Options [] · Tradeoff [] · Temporary test answer [] · Evidence needed [] · Final answer [open] · Review trigger [].

5 Explore the underworld destinations

The destination idea can change the core question from only who boards to who travels together and where they go. The location should affect a choice the player can understand before committing. These identities and mechanics are fictional design proposals.

Three viable routing models

Model	What the player chooses	What it adds	Cost to the design
One destination per crossing	A route and one boat composition	Competing passenger needs within the current loop	Risk of repetitive grouping by destination
Multiple stops	An itinerary using a shared travel budget	Route order, disembarking, and mixed passengers	More time, states, and exceptions; capacity may matter less
Conditional passage	Whether to use a paid or temporary opening	Anticipation and memorable opportunities	Requires clear signals; inaccessible routes can frustrate

TRIAL choice: Start with one destination per crossing. Test a timed opening later while keeping the same boarding rules. This makes the effect of each addition easier to observe.

Destination concepts to develop

Elysium, preservation. A quiet destination where a cherished memory remains vivid. One soul seeks peace; another fears being held inside an idealized past. Possible later mechanic: preserve a memory or repeat its effect. Possible access: a paid passage permit, a patron's invitation, or a brief opening. The team decides who may enter and whether anyone can refuse.

Asphodel, release and belonging. A destination where individual distinctions soften. Anonymity can be relief for one passenger and loss for another. Possible later mechanic: share or redistribute an effect among souls. Possible access: dependable public passage. The team decides whether this is the regular route and what arrival means for identity.

Tartarus, reckoning. A destination for confronting unfinished obligations. A witness, companion, or accountable figure may have a reason to travel there. Possible later mechanic: accept a known obligation now and resolve it later. Possible access: a commission, summons, escort contract, or temporary opening. The team decides whether Charon is enforcing, witnessing, or helping someone seek redress.

These concepts do not assign souls a numerical moral worth. If the team wants judgment to be part of play, specify who judges, what the player knows, and how disagreement becomes an action.

Complete route example for the first test

Route	Cost paid at departure	Base river pressure	Arrival effect
Elysium	1 banked obol per boat	0	Printed soul rewards
Asphodel	0	1	Printed soul rewards
Tartarus	0	2	Printed rewards plus 1 service obol if at least one soul arrives

Route IDs: EL01 Elysium, AS01 Asphodel, and TA01 Tartarus.

TRIAL only: All three routes are open and all souls are eligible. The table tests safety versus money, not the final fiction. Fees belong to Charon, and fares arrive afterward. There is no direct exchange between obols and Standing, although route safety creates an indirect economic tradeoff worth measuring.

TEAM DECISION: Should each location change only travel risk, or also the fate of a soul and the residue it leaves? [answer]. Keep the simple table for the first comparison; develop destination-specific residue only if the route choice earns its complexity.

6 Ready to run paper trial

TRIAL objective: Complete six crossings while meeting the announced quotas. Explain a difficult choice after the run. This is a temporary testing objective, not the final game's victory condition. Any diagnostic continuation after failure must be labeled as such.

Materials and setup

Use twelve soul slips from section 9, one boat with four seat slots, a shore, a separate wraith area, obol and Standing counters, three route slips, and residue slips from section 10. One person plays Charon; one facilitates. An observer records the run if available.

Setting	Trial value
Crossings	6
Boat capacity	4 seats throughout
Available shore	Refill to 5 souls each crossing
Soul supply order	S01 through S12, no shuffle
Starting resources	2 obols and 3 Standing
Starting residue	Empty draw queue, hand, and discard
Hand and play limit	Draw up to 2; play at most 1 each crossing
Residue activation	Pay 1 Standing during Load
Quota	Pay 3 obols after arrival on crossings 3 and 6
Wraith threshold	3 refusals; each existing wraith adds 1 pressure
Event module	Off; only the visible route pressure applies

Label residue copies with their source soul ID as they are acquired. Each delivered soul creates one card instance, even when multiple souls yield the same residue type. Prepare two R05 slips for each linked pair that might arrive together.

What the player can do

During Load, inspect all cards, choose one route, select passengers costing at most four seats, and optionally commit one residue with any required target. Rearrange freely before confirming. Empty seats and an empty departure are legal. Seats measure capacity only; position and adjacency have no effect. Nothing may be changed after confirmation.

The displayed supply order, all soul rewards, all route conditions, and both quota dates are known. This trial uses no hidden information. Soul requests in section 9 are conversation prompts; they do not restrict travel or alter rewards in this version.

7 Game Master procedure

Use this sequence without adding discretionary rulings. If a rule is missing, write the question down and agree a temporary ruling visibly before continuing.

1. **Shore.** Keep waiting souls and their refusal counters. Refill available spaces to five using the next supply cards. New souls start at zero refusals. Wraiths are separate and never occupy a shore slot. When supply is exhausted, the shore may contain fewer than five souls.
2. **Recall.** Draw up to two residue cards from the front of the queue. If it empties, move discard cards into the queue in oldest-discarded-first order. Do not shuffle. If fewer than two cards exist, draw only those available.
3. **Load.** Choose the route, passengers, and optional residue. Confirm all targets and validate capacity and payment. Pay the route toll from current obols and the residue cost from current Standing. Future fares cannot cover these costs.
4. **Cross.** Read aboard effects from the locked boat. Each applies once. Pressure equals route pressure plus existing wraiths plus conflict modifiers, minus protection. Clamp pressure to zero. If Standing is at least pressure, subtract it and continue. Otherwise end before arrival with no delivery rewards.
5. **Arrive.** Collect printed fares and Standing yields from delivered souls. Collect any route service payment. Select solo or joint residue variants from the boat's composition. Put each new residue card at the bottom of the draw queue in ascending soul ID order. It cannot be played this crossing. Record every soul's destination in the delivery history.
6. **Quota.** On crossings three and six, pay three obols. If the bank contains fewer than three, record quota failure. Arrival income is available for this payment.
7. **Decay.** Every soul left on the shore receives one normal refusal unless protected from normal decay. Apply any extra separation refusal. At three or more refusals, flip the soul into the wraith area. New wraiths first add pressure next crossing.
8. **Cleanup.** Put the played residue in discard first, then unplayed hand cards in left-to-right order. Clear the boat, retaining its delivered souls in the history area. Advance the crossing counter. End after crossing six if no earlier failure occurred.

Timing rules that settle common disputes

- The opening deck is empty. The first crossing therefore has no residue play.
- A soul arriving during Shore can receive its first refusal during that crossing's Decay.
- A linked pair yields its joint residue only when both arrive on the same crossing.
- Extra separation decay occurs only when both linked souls were on the shore at departure and exactly one boards. Add one extra refusal to the waiting partner, once.
- A partner still in supply, already delivered, or already a wraith cannot trigger separation decay. Later delivery never upgrades an old residue card.
- Protection prevents pressure; it never restores Standing. Resources cannot become negative.
- Wraiths persist, cannot board, and yield no fares or residue in this trial.
- Empty crossings still incur route costs, pressure, quotas, and decay. They receive no Tartarus service payment.
- There are no purchases, discards by choice, culling, route changes, or reactive plays outside Load.

8 Worked crossing and boundary examples

A complete first crossing

TRIAL setup: The shore contains S01 Mother, S02 Child, S03 Merchant, S04 Red Soldier, and S05 Poet. The bank has two obols and three Standing. No residue or wraiths exist.

Choice: Take Mother, Child, and Poet to Asphodel. Their seat costs are $2 + 1 + 1 = 4$. Pay no route toll and play no residue.

Cross: Asphodel contributes one pressure. Poet grants one protection because two other souls are aboard. Pressure is $\max(0, 1 - 1) = 0$. Standing stays at three.

Arrive: All three souls have zero fare. Each yields one Standing, so Standing becomes six. Mother and Child each produce R05 Joined Memory; Poet produces R03 Recollection. Add these in S01, S02, S05 order. The obol bank stays at two.

Decay and cleanup: Merchant and Red Soldier each gain one refusal. No quota is due. At the next Shore, add S06, S07, and S08 to return the shore to five. The next hand contains the two R05 cards. This choice preserved a family and built Standing, but earned no money toward the first quota.

Four edge examples

Separation: Mother waits at one refusal while Child boards. With both available at departure, Mother gains one normal and one extra refusal, reaching three. She becomes a wraith after arrival and contributes pressure starting next crossing.

Insufficient toll: Elysium costs one banked obol. With zero obols at departure, it is unavailable even if every selected passenger carries a fare. Choose an affordable route before locking the boat.

Standing timing: With two Standing, playing one residue leaves one before pressure. A final pressure of one is survivable and leaves zero. A final pressure of two ends the run before fare and Standing rewards can arrive.

No supply: If all twelve souls have left the supply, refill adds nothing. Available souls can still board. An empty shore does not cancel the remaining crossing, its quota, or existing wraith pressure.

TEAM EXERCISE: Replay the first crossing with Merchant aboard. Write the boat [], route [], end resources [], waiting souls [], and why the team prefers or rejects it [].

9 Soul examples and reusable cards

Twelve complete mechanical examples

TRIAL: One unique soul instance exists for each ID. Seats are occupied until arrival. A fare of one pays one obol on arrival; a fare of zero pays none. The Standing column is also an arrival reward. No listed soul adds pressure or protection unless its effect says so.

ID and soul	Seats	Fare	Standing	Residue	Aboard or link rule
S01 Mother	2	0	1	R06 solo; R05 joint	Linked to S02
S02 Child	1	0	1	R06 solo; R05 joint	Linked to S01
S03 Merchant	1	1	0	R02	None
S04 Red Soldier	2	1	0	R04	With S06, add 1 conflict pressure once per boat
S05 Poet	1	0	1	R03	Grant 1 protection if at least two other souls are aboard
S06 Blue Soldier	1	1	0	R04	With S04, add 1 conflict pressure once per boat
S07 Cook	1	0	1	R03	None
S08 Mason	2	1	0	R02	None
S09 Messenger	1	1	0	R01	None
S10 Keeper	2	0	1	R01	Grant 1 protection if this is the only passenger
S11 Musician	1	0	1	R06 solo; R05 joint	Linked to S12
S12 Listener	1	1	0	R06 solo; R05 joint	Linked to S11

All four linked souls use the separation rule in section 7. The soldiers' shared conflict is one unordered pair, so their two cards never double its pressure. All twelve wraith backs say: starting next crossing, add one pressure while this wraith remains active.

Story and request examples

These short lines are optional flavor in the first trial. They become mechanical only if the team activates a wishes rule from section 19. A fare indicates payment available, not virtue.

Soul	Sample line	Suggested request or tension
Mother	I told him I would be there when he woke.	Wants to stay with Child; no named destination
Child	Will the boat remember the way back?	Follows Mother; may later have a different wish
Merchant	The coin is yours. The name on it is mine.	Elysium; fears anonymity
Red Soldier	Someone on this shore knows what happened.	Tartarus as a place of testimony
Poet	Let me tell their names while there is still time.	Asphodel; fears losing other people's stories
Blue Soldier	The war has ended for everyone except us.	Asphodel; seeks release from conflict
Cook	I made enough for everyone. I always did.	Asphodel; values company
Mason	There is one wall I never finished.	Tartarus; wishes to confront an obligation
Messenger	I arrived too late. The message did not.	Elysium; wants a memory preserved
Keeper	I kept the light burning for someone else.	No request; asks who still waits
Musician	The last verse belongs to someone here.	Stay with Listener
Listener	I never told her I knew the song.	Stay with Musician; reveal an unfinished conversation

Copyable soul card template

Identity: ID [] · Name [] · Version [] · Owner [] · Status [TRIAL / approved]

Visible front: One-line story [] · Seats [] · Fare [] · Arrival Standing [] · Tags [] · Destination request [none or ID] · Eligibility [unrestricted or exact rule].

Relationships: Partner ID [none or ID] · Both aboard effect [] · Exactly one aboard effect [] · Partner absent rule [] · Whether this stacks [].

Aboard rule: Trigger [] · Target [] · Timing [] · Numeric effect [] · Limit [] · No-valid-target behavior [].

Residue: Solo type [] · Joint type [] · Destination variant [off or mapping] · Entry zone and timing [].

Waiting and wraith back: Normal refusal [] · Extra trigger [] · Transform threshold [] · First action timing [] · Wraith effect [] · Recovery condition [off or exact rule].

Narrative: Reveal trigger [] · Delivery line [] · Refusal line [] · Return condition [none or exact condition] · Myth reference or invented status [].

Test: The choice this card creates [] · Possible dominant pairing [] · Confusion to watch [] · Observation [blank until played].

Expanding the catalogue

Reserve S13 to S20 as empty authoring slots if the team wants to reach the report's approximate twenty-card starting estimate. [R, pp. 3 to 4] Add a card because it introduces a distinct decision, relationship, or consequence. Record the reason before writing the card. Do not count these empty slots as playable content.

10 Residue and deck mechanics

The report's intent is a deck that records the carried dead rather than a conventional power ladder. [R, p. 1] The trial uses a queue to make each test reproducible. A random deck, a visible tableau, and active memories with an archive remain team alternatives.

Complete residue examples

TRIAL common rule: Pay one Standing and commit at most one card during Load. Name any target before confirmation. Resolve its effect during Cross or Decay as stated. The card goes to discard during Cleanup, whether its conditional effect succeeds or not.

ID and name	Exact effect	Source in trial
R01 Steadiness	Grant 2 protection during Cross	S09 and S10
R02 Vigil	Grant 3 protection if at least one passenger has printed seat cost 2; otherwise grant 0	S03 and S08
R03 Recollection	Name one soul staying ashore. Prevent its one normal refusal this crossing. Extra separation refusal still applies	S05 and S07
R04 Accord	Cancel the S04 and S06 conflict modifier if present, and grant 1 protection	S04 and S06
R05 Joined Memory	Grant 2 protection. Also name one waiting soul to prevent its normal refusal; extra separation still applies	Each member of a jointly delivered linked pair
R06 Faint Memory	Grant 1 protection	A linked soul delivered without its partner

R05 intentionally rewards carrying a pair together. R06 is a diminished variant. This is an explicit trial interpretation of the report's linked-residue idea, not evidence that any resulting deck is balanced.

Card movement and targeting

Draw queue -> hand -> committed card -> discard -> draw queue. Newly delivered residue enters the bottom of the draw queue. Source-soul history remains in a separate ledger even if a future rule removes its active card.

For R03 or R05, select a legal waiting soul if one exists. If the shore will be empty, the decay-prevention part has no effect; the card remains playable. A card never shields an already active wraith. Prevention lasts only for the current crossing. Multiple protection sources add together before pressure is clamped.

Copyable residue template

ID / name / source soul / version: []

Meaning: What remains of this person's life? [one sentence]

When acquired: [arrival condition and variant selection]

When played: [phase] · **Cost:** [resource and timing] · **Limit:** [per crossing or run]

Target: [legal target] · **Effect:** [exact action and value] · **Duration:** []

If condition fails: [] · **If no target exists:** [] · **Stacking:** []

After use: [discard, archive, or remove] · **History retained:** []

Test comparison: [which other card offers a different capability] · **Result:** [].

TEAM DECISION: Is memory expendable, forgettable, replaceable, or permanent? Describe how the mechanic supports the intended emotional meaning before implementing culling. Use section 19 for a reversible archive experiment.

11 Destination and event templates

Completed destination sheet

TRIAL route EL01 Elysium: A route about preservation. Its first-test function is a paid reduction in immediate river pressure.

Access: Always open in the basic trial. **Eligibility:** All souls. **Cost:** One obol per boat from the current bank when Load is confirmed. **Pressure:** Zero before wraiths and other modifiers.

Arrival: Printed fares, Standing, and residue. **Return:** Abstracted; no extra action or cost.

Failure: Ordinary crossing failure, with no toll refund.

Player information: Show the toll, base pressure, selected passengers, total expected pressure, and post-payment resources before confirming. A closed or unaffordable route states its reason.

Open narrative choice: Why does this route demand payment, and who collects it? [team answer]. **Test question:** Does paying for safety produce a real quota tradeoff? **Result:** [record route choices and remaining obols].

Copyable destination template

ID / name / owner / version: [] · **Status:** []

Identity and purpose: [fictional meaning] · **Decision created:** []

Authority: [who assigns passage] · **Soul request handling:** []

Access trigger and duration: [] · **Price and payer:** [] · **Payment timing:** []

Eligibility: [exact requirements] · **Closed-route behavior:** [] · **Affordable fallback:** []

Travel pressure or event: [] · **Aboard interactions:** [] · **Arrival reward:** []

Residue variant: [off or mapping] · **Persistent consequence:** [] · **Return journey:** []

Cancel, failure, and refund rules: [] · **Visible preview:** []

Myth source and adaptation: [source / changed detail] · **Playtest question:** [].

Four completed visible event examples

TRIAL extension, off by default: In an event test, reveal the event before Load. Resolve its specified effect only on that crossing. Keep route pressure; apply event changes before protection. Use the known order E01, E02, E03, E04, then no event on crossings five and six. This adds events without a hidden draw.

ID and event	Visible rule	What it tests
E01 Still Water	Reduce route base pressure by 1, minimum 0. Wraith pressure is unchanged	Whether a calm crossing changes the chosen route
E02 Heavy Current	If any aboard soul has printed seat cost 2, add 1 pressure once	Whether size competes with links and fares

ID and event	Visible rule	What it tests
E03 Open Gate	Elysium's toll is 0 for this crossing; other rules stay the same	Whether a temporary price window changes priorities
E04 Roll Call	At arrival, gain 1 extra Standing if at least one delivered soul had 2 refusals at departure, once per boat	Whether urgency matters when a waiting soul can still be helped

E03 tests a discount, not an access restriction. The separate gate-access module in section 19 tests closed routes. Do not treat them as interchangeable versions of one rule.

Copyable event template

ID / title / version / owner: []

Source or invented motif: [] · **Short visible cue:** []

Reveal timing: [] · **Trigger:** [] · **Affected routes, souls, or tags:** []

Exact rule: [] · **Duration and reset:** [] · **Stacking and cap:** []

Player counterplay: [action before commitment] · **No-valid-target outcome:** []

Interaction with failure and quota: [] · **Test hypothesis and result:** [].

12 System specification and economy

Every implemented mechanic needs a precise rule and an observable consequence. Use one sheet per system. A system is ready for a test when another team member can resolve it from the sheet without asking its author.

Master mechanics register

System	Inputs and state	Outputs and interactions	Rule location
Shore supply	Ordered soul supply, waiting IDs, refusal counters	Five available slots, persistent wait	Sections 6 and 7
Capacity and boarding	Selected IDs and seat costs	Valid load or explanatory rejection	Sections 6 and 7
Routes	Access, bank, route pressure	Paid toll and destination	Sections 5 and 11
Soul wishes	Request and chosen route	Flavor initially; optional consequence	Sections 9 and 19
Links and composition	Locked passenger IDs	Joint residue, conflict, protection, separation	Sections 7 and 9
Residue	Queue, hand, discard, Standing	Protection or decay prevention	Section 10
Crossing resolution	Pressure sources and protection	Standing deduction or failure	Sections 7 and 8
Arrival and history	Surviving passengers and destination	Fares, Standing, residue, ledger entries	Section 7
Quota	Crossing number and bank	Obol deduction or failure	Sections 6 and 7
Decay and wraiths	Waiting counters and prevention	Refusal, transformation, later pressure	Section 7
Events and gates	Visible event, access duration	Current rule modifiers	Sections 11 and 19
Progression and ending	Run state and team objective	Unlocks, run closure, restart	Sections 13 and 19
Interaction and saving	Input, confirmed actions, state version	Valid transitions and recoverable session	Sections 14 and 16

Complete system example

TRIAL SYS07 Refusal and wraith pressure

Purpose: A refusal changes later crossings. **State:** Each waiting soul has an integer refusal count; active wraiths are stored separately.

Rule: During Decay, add one normal refusal unless prevented. Add one separation refusal when the section 7 condition holds. At three or more, transform the soul and remove it from the available shore. Beginning next crossing, each active wraith adds one pressure. No wraith-removal action exists in the basic trial.

Feedback: Show every soul's current count and preview its post-departure count. Show new transformations separately from pressure that already applied. **Boundary:** Recollection prevents normal decay, not the separation penalty. **Risk:** Persistent pressure may create a run that cannot recover. **Evidence:** Record the crossing of each transformation and any later turn with no survivable legal load.

Copyable system specification

ID / name / owner / version / status: []

Player purpose: [decision or feedback created]

Stored state and starting values: []

Inputs and legal actions: [] · **Preconditions:** []

Exact resolution order: [numbered actions]

Outputs and state changes: [] · **Costs and gains:** []

Timing and duration: [] · **Targeting, stacking, and tie rules:** []

Exceptions: [empty state, missing target, exhausted supply, insufficient resource, simultaneous effects]

Visible information and explanation: []

Dependencies and incompatible modules: []

Tuning values: [value / reason / allowed test range]

Worked example: [before -> action -> after]

Acceptance scenario: [setup / expected result] · **Playtest result:** [].

Economy ledger

Resource	Trial sources	Trial sinks	Meaning and risk
Obols	Start 2; printed fares; Tartarus service 1	Elysium toll 1; quotas of 3	Funds passage; route income may become repetitive
Standing	Start 3; printed arrival yields	Residue activation 1; resolved pressure	Enables survival and memories; can snowball or collapse
Seats	Four slots each crossing	Printed costs of selected souls	A per-crossing constraint, never a stored currency
Refusals	Normal decay and separation	R03/R05 prevent normal additions	Persistent urgency; prevention does not erase history
Residue	One instance per delivered soul	No permanent removal in trial	Accumulated choices; growing queue can delay useful cards

Economic identity: Obols and Standing cannot directly buy one another. Their uses still interact through routes and cards. Test whether one repeated strategy can produce both cheaply enough to erase the intended tradeoff.

Copyable tuning row: Variable [] · Current value [] · Reason [] · Proposed change [] · Expected effect [] · Test setup held constant [] · Actual observation [].

13 Progression narrative and the shape of a run

The report leaves the final endpoint open and describes residue as a record of the carried dead. [R, pp. 1 and 4] **TRIAL:** Memories, waiting souls, and quotas create change across six crossings without upgrades or permanent unlocks. Test whether that arc feels satisfying.

Completed run outline

Moment	Playable example	Narrative function
Opening	Show S01 to S05, four seats, two obols, three Standing, and both quota dates	Establish a service with visible limits
First departure	Present the selected boat and its waiting souls together	Make the choice and its immediate cost readable
Return	Show acquired residue and updated refusal counters	Connect the next crossing to the previous one
Crossing three	Collect arrival rewards, then charge the first three-obol quota	Bring financial obligations into the accumulated history
Later crossings	Continue the same rules with the actual queue, shore, and wraiths	Let consequences create pressure without scripted escalation
Closure	End on pressure failure, quota failure, or completed crossing six	State what happened and invite reflection
Restart	Restore section 6 setup and clear run state	Permit a different sequence of choices

TRIAL closing screen: “The crossing record closes here.” Display endpoint, delivered soul IDs and destinations, undelivered souls including any locked boat, active wraiths, and remaining resources. Ask: “Which choice would you reconsider?” Do not invent a virtue grade. A pressure failure grants no arrival rewards; a quota failure follows arrival.

Completed linked story example

N01, The unfinished song: S11 Musician and S12 Listener already form a linked pair. On their first simultaneous appearance on the shore, show their section 9 lines. If both arrive together, add: “At the far bank, she sings the verse he had kept.” Each yields R05 under the existing rules. If only one arrives, show: “The final verse has no answer.” That soul yields R06. The waiting partner follows ordinary and separation decay rules. If the other soul later arrives, record that later journey without changing the earlier residue.

Trigger each proposed line once, with no additional reward. The story may remain unseen. Wishes remain flavor only.

Copyable narrative and progression sheet

Arc ID / owner / version: [] · **Experience sought:** []

Opening state: [] · **Recurring choice:** [] · **Change across crossings:** []

Beat: [text] · **Exact trigger:** [] · **Repeat limit:** [] · **If skipped:** []

Mechanical consequence: [none or rule ID] · **History recorded:** []

Endpoint / failure treatment / reflection prompt: [] · **Restart state:** []

TEAM DECISION, D06 and D11: Fixed run, endless duty, or another structure? What persists between runs, if anything? What interpretation should the ending leave to the player?

14 Interface onboarding and accessibility

TRIAL: Keep supply order, rewards, route conditions, and quota dates visible.

Completed screen flow

1. **Start:** State the temporary aim, complete six crossings and pay the two quotas. Offer start, rules, and settings.
2. **Shore and Recall:** Show current resources, crossing number, upcoming quota, available souls, waiting counts, active wraiths, and the hand drawn by the procedure.
3. **Load:** Inspect a soul, toggle boarding, choose a route, and optionally select one residue and its target. Provide the same actions through buttons as through dragging.
4. **Departure review:** Show occupied seats, toll paid now, residue cost paid now, pressure calculation, expected arrival rewards, and projected refusal changes. Distinguish money already banked from fares earned on arrival.
5. **Resolution:** Present Cross, Arrive, Quota, and Decay in order. Acknowledge the result, then continue to the next crossing or run record.

Completed preview: With S01, S02, and S05 selected for Asphodel on crossing one: “Seats 4/4. Toll 0. Pressure: route 1 + wraiths 0 + conflict 0 - protection 1 = 0. Standing after arrival 6. Obols after arrival 2. S03 and S04 reach refusal 1.” The calculation matches section 8. Future rewards appear conditional on successful arrival.

Feedback and error example

With zero banked obols, selecting Elysium shows: “Requires 1 obol before departure. Current bank: 0.” Keep the selection editable. A five-seat boat shows the selected capacity total and explains why confirmation is unavailable. A legal departure whose pressure would exceed Standing instead shows its predicted run-ending consequence clearly. Decide with the team whether that action needs an additional confirmation; do not silently change the rules.

Accessibility requirements for the prototype

- Pair each icon and color with a text label. Show refusal as a number as well as markers.
- Support selecting, inspecting, boarding, removing, choosing routes, and confirming without precise dragging. Keep focus visible and ordered.
- Make critical effects available through explicit inspection, without relying on hover, sound, or animation.
- Allow larger text and verify that long card text and enlarged labels remain readable.
- Provide readable dialogue text, separate sound controls, and reduced-motion or instant-resolution options. Animation speed must not change results.

Copyable screen and onboarding template

Screen / player task / entry state: []

Essential information: [] · **Actions:** [] · **Input alternatives:** []

Preview calculation: [] · **Invalid action and explanation:** []

Focus order / reading order / enlarged-text behavior: []

Sound or motion cue and text equivalent: [] · **Exit state:** []

Teach now: [one rule] · **Teach later:** [] · **Observed confusion:** [blank until tested].

TEAM DECISION, D12: Target platform and input methods remain open. Agree them before committing the digital layout.

15 Art audio and an achievable asset scope

Presentation should identify souls, costs, links, destinations, and consequences. **TRIAL:** Start with readable cards and counters. These briefs specify proposed assets, not finished artwork or audio.

Three direction options

Ink and lantern light: Sparse silhouettes, textured paper, and warm light. A restrained atmosphere needs distinct silhouettes so characters remain recognizable.

Ceremonial ledger: Stamps, seals, and ordered records emphasize Charon's service. Test whether bureaucratic distance weakens attachment to souls.

Painted river theatre: Layered banks, expressive portraits, and destination backdrops offer more expression with greater asset demands. All three are invented directions, not ancient visual practice.

Completed starter inventory

Priority	Asset request	Minimum useful treatment
Needed for paper	Twelve soul fronts and a shared wraith-back design	Names, seats, fares, effects, IDs, refusal markers
Needed for paper	Six residue type layouts, with source-labelled copies	Cost, effect, target, and timing
Needed for route test	Three route panels	Name, toll, pressure, and arrival effect
Needed for paper	Boat, shore, wraith area, and resource trackers	Clear zones and four visible seat slots
Needed for digital slice	Buttons, focus states, selected states, and error treatment	Readable interaction without final illustration
Optional polish	Portraits, destination backdrops, transitions, and ambience	Add after the team selects a direction

Shared frames and icons can support later content.

Completed audio brief

Cue AU01, departure commitment: Play a brief rope-release and water movement cue after a valid Load confirmation. Its purpose is to mark commitment. The text “Departure confirmed” and the resolution panel communicate the same event when muted. Do not play it while merely rearranging passengers. Reloading a committed state must not repeat its gameplay effects.

Optional wraith transformation and quota cues should identify events through paired text. Avoid assigning a triumphant sound to one destination unless the team deliberately wants that judgment.

Copyable visual or audio brief

Asset ID / owner / status / required stage: []

Purpose and player information conveyed: [] · **Used by rule or screen:** []

Direction / references / invented or sourced details: []

Required states or trigger: [] · **Dimensions or duration:** [to be agreed]

Text, contrast, focus, or mute fallback: [] · **Placeholder:** []

Acceptance check: [readable at intended size; distinguishable state; correct trigger]

TEAM DECISION, D12: Approve fidelity, source and licensing of assets, and optional polish only against the team's available effort.

16 Digital systems handoff

This proposed implementation contract leaves the engine open. Reproduce sections 6 to 11 before adding mechanics. No executable prototype is supplied.

Data and state examples

Record	Required information
Run	Rules version, enabled modules, phase, crossing, obols, Standing, endpoint
Soul definition	S01 to S12 identity, seats, fare, Standing yield, link, effect, residue variants
Soul instance	Definition ID, zone, refusal count, delivery destination and crossing
Residue instance	R01 to R06 type, source soul ID, unique instance key, queue/hand/discard position
Route definition	Stable ID, name, toll, pressure, arrival effect, access rule
Departure	Locked passengers, route, residue instance, target, paid costs, starting wraith IDs
History	Ordered actions, resolved changes, narrative triggers already shown

R05 from S01 and S02 are separate instances with distinct histories and queue positions. Use EL01 for Elysium, AS01 for Asphodel, and TA01 for Tartarus.

Preview and confirmation

TRIAL contract: Preview calculates an outcome without changing state. Confirmation validates against current state; reject invalid commands without partial payment. The cycle is Shore, Recall, Load, Cross, Arrive, Quota, Decay, Cleanup. At valid Load confirmation, store the departure and costs once, then advance to Cross.

Snapshot the boat for relationship checks. Count the S04/S06 conflict once. Keep normal decay prevention distinct from extra separation decay. Take wraith pressure from wraiths active for this crossing; transformations during its Decay begin acting next crossing. Rendering or replaying an animation must never apply a rule again.

Completed acceptance examples

- Section 8's first departure produces zero pressure, six Standing, two obols, and newly acquired residue in S01, S02, S05 order.
- Zero banked obols rejects Elysium even when selected souls would later pay fares. State remains unchanged.
- S01 waiting at one refusal while S02 boards reaches three at Decay without protection. With R03 normal-decay prevention, S01 reaches two because extra separation still applies.
- A nonempty Tartarus arrival earns its one service obol; an empty departure does not.

These are expected results from the written rules, not completed software tests.

Saving and content validation

For a first digital slice, save at stable phase boundaries, including any committed departure and pending resolution. On reload, restore queue order and the phase cursor so costs are not charged twice. Reject incompatible save versions with an explanation until a migration rule exists. Validate unique IDs, referenced partners, residue mappings, nonnegative costs, and resolvable effect types when loading content.

Copyable handoff: Entity/state [] · Command [] · Preconditions [] · Ordered changes [] · Failure behavior [] · Saved fields [] · Log entry [] · Acceptance setup/action/expected state [] · Actual result [].

17 Prototype stages and development backlog

Each stage answers a question. Exit conditions are **proposed checks**, not completed results. The immediate target is C01, the coming-week paper showcase detailed in section 17A. The team assigns the exact date and retains platform, engine, and production decisions under D12.

Stage	Build or prepare	Question and proposed exit evidence
P01 One crossing	Opening five souls, counters, boat, routes	Can a cold tester identify the capacity limit and explain the departure? Record mistakes and explanations
P02 Full paper run	Entire twelve-soul kit and deterministic residue	Can a facilitator complete all transitions without inventing rules? Record every ruling
C01 Coming-week showcase	Frozen paper kit, short demo, full rehearsal, reset and feedback sheets	Is the packet ready for visitors? Complete the section 17A checklist and record actual evidence
P03 Route comparison	Same core setup with a controlled route variation	Does route choice change boarding or resource planning? Compare action records
P04 Optional myth mechanic	One selected section 19 or 20 module	Does the addition create the intended choice without obscuring existing costs? Log its uses and confusion
P05 Digital rules model	Data, transition procedure, preview, and action log	Do hand-calculated acceptance scenarios match the model? Record expected and actual states
P06 Playable digital slice	Complete start-to-end interface with placeholders	Can testers inspect, commit, understand failure, finish, and restart without facilitator rulings?
P07 Expanded whole-run prototype	Team-approved content, progression, persistence, and presentation	Does the agreed full-run structure remain understandable as content grows? Test the complete route to closure

Optional myth exploration need not block the digital model. If a check fails, revise a specific rule or reconsider the design aim before adding complexity.

Completed backlog examples

B01, clarify commitment: Prepare the departure preview from section 14. Depends on final trial timing. Done for a paper test when it displays immediate costs, pressure, arrival rewards, and refusal changes for the selected boat. Evidence: a facilitator can reproduce section 8 from the display.

B02, preserve memory identity: Add source-soul labels to residue copies. Depends on the soul catalogue. Done when the two R05 copies gained from S01 and S02 can be distinguished and their acquisition order recovered.

B03, evaluate route access: Choose one section 19 access module, specify its visible trigger and duration, and compare it with the base trial. Depends on D03 approval.

Copyable stage and backlog template

Stage/item ID / owner / priority: [] · **Player or testing purpose:** []

Deliverable: [] · **Included rules:** [] · **Explicitly deferred:** []

Dependencies / team decisions needed: []

Acceptance evidence: [observable behavior or exact state] · **Result:** []

Effort estimate / target date: [team fills] · **Next action if unmet:** [].

Reconcile conflicting rules, update the version, and retain each tested version with its observations.

17A Paper prototype showcase checkpoint

USER REQUIREMENT U2: The team needs a paper prototype to showcase the game idea in the coming week. **Checkpoint C01:** Demonstrate a playable, understandable version of the central choice, then capture what the audience understood and where it struggled. This checkpoint prepares the team for the showcase; it does not approve the final game design.

Target: Coming week. **Showcase date and time:** [confirm] · **Available demo time:** [confirm] · **Audience and table space:** [confirm] · **Confirmed course requirements:** [record]. Do not assume a submission format or exact deadline from this plan.

What the showcase should communicate

A visitor should be able to make a boarding and destination choice, see its consequence, and explain one tradeoff. The demonstration should introduce limited capacity, money versus Standing, relationships, remembered souls, and the cost of leaving someone behind. Demonstrate the mechanisms; claims about balance or enjoyment still need observations.

TRIAL showcase scope: Use the twelve souls, six base residue types, and three always-open destinations from sections 5 to 10. Keep four seats, the fixed supply order, visible rewards, the two quotas, and the existing refusal rules. River events and optional modules stay off for this checkpoint unless the team explicitly replaces the scope before rehearsal. Final art, engine selection, and long-term progression do not block the paper showcase.

TEAM DECISION: Confirm this temporary scope, the available demo length, and who owns readiness. These choices can be made for the showcase without settling Charon's final authority, destination eligibility, or the full game's ending.

Physical kit and handover

Item	Preparation requirement	Owner
Soul set	12 numbered soul cards, S01 to S12, with readable costs and effects, refusal markers, and wraith backs	[name]
Residue set	12 source-labelled card instances, one per possible delivery. The four linked souls must each support both the R05 joint and R06 solo variant; mark the acquired variant clearly	[name]
Routes	3 visible slips showing destination, departure toll, pressure, and arrival reward	[name]
Play area	Four-seat boat, shore, wraith area, delivery history, and residue queue, hand, and discard zones	[name]
Counters	Obols, Standing, refusal markers, crossing marker, and a reminder of quotas on crossings 3 and 6	[name]
Reference packet	Quick summary, GM procedure, card text, observation sheet, reset checklist, and the same packet version on all rule sheets	[name]

Use handwritten slips, paper counters, and a drawn board if needed. Readability and complete information matter at this checkpoint. Keep spare blank slips for corrections. Assign a facilitator, component owner, observer, and reset or backup owner; one person may cover more than one role.

Proposed preparation plan for the week

These are relative work stages, not confirmed calendar dates. If fewer days are available, combine stages while preserving the rehearsal and readiness check.

Stage	Team task	Evidence of completion
Day 1	Confirm showcase logistics and temporary scope; assign owners and packet version	Dated scope note and named owners
Days 2 and 3	Produce the complete physical kit and reference sheets	Inventory checked against the table above
Day 4	Rehearse the full six-crossing trial, or resolve its correct early failure; separately exercise unreached boundary cases	Recorded actions, timing, missing rules, and corrections
Day 5	Run the short demonstration with a person who did not prepare the rules, if available	Explanation time, visitor choices, help requests, and feedback
Before showcase	Apply essential clarity fixes, repeat affected checks, freeze the packet, and rehearse reset	Completed C01 checklist and packed kit
After showcase	Review observations and choose one next change	Checkpoint outcome and one assigned follow-up

Do not quietly change rules between visitors. Record a necessary correction, update the packet version, and identify which observations used each version.

Short demonstration plan

Proposed format: Allow approximately 8 to 10 minutes if the showcase slot permits, then adjust using measured rehearsal time. This is a planning target, not an observed duration. A full six-crossing rehearsal remains separate from the short visitor demonstration.

1. **Introduce the choice.** Explain that Charon chooses who fits in the boat and where it goes. Point out the four seats, banked obols, Standing, and the quota reminder. State the temporary trial objective.
2. **Let the visitor decide.** Start from the normal opening shore S01 to S05. Let the visitor choose a route and legal load. Explain immediate costs and visible consequences without choosing for them.
3. **Resolve and return.** Follow the GM sequence. Show acquired residue and updated refusal counters, then offer another crossing if time allows. A third crossing can also expose the first quota and possible wraith creation, depending on actual choices.
4. **Explain anything not reached.** Use the worked examples in section 8 to explain third-refusal timing or failure if these did not occur. Label these as illustrations, not events from the visitor's run. Any prepared later-state snapshot must record resources, queues, counters, and prior deliveries.
5. **Ask and reset.** Ask what affected the choice and what was unclear. Record an observation before resetting for the next visitor. If the slot allows only one crossing, use a brief illustrated recap instead of changing the rules to force a later outcome.

Example introduction: You are Charon. Your boat has four seats, but more souls are waiting. Choose who travels and which destination to visit. Fares help meet your quota, memories affect later crossings, and people left behind keep waiting. What will you do with this departure?

An early failure is a valid demonstration outcome. Explain its cause. Restart or label any continued play as a diagnostic continuation; do not silently cancel a cost or declare a successful run.

C01 readiness checklist

The items below are proposed acceptance checks. They are not completed results. The checkpoint owner records the actual evidence and decides whether the packet is ready.

- ☐ The exact showcase date, available time, logistics, and any course requirements are recorded.
- ☐ No required component is missing, and all rule sheets match the frozen packet version.
- ☐ A full rehearsal reaches crossing six or resolves a correct early failure without an unresolved or improvised rule.
- ☐ Capacity rejection, residue play, joint and solo residue, third-refusal transformation, pressure failure, quota failure, and reset have each been checked, using separate examples when the rehearsal did not reach them.
- ☐ The facilitator can show when a new wraith first acts and why future fares cannot pay a departure toll.
- ☐ At least one rehearsal participant has made a choice and explained a tradeoff. Record whether that participant helped design the rules; a fresh perspective is preferred, not assumed.
- ☐ Actual explanation, play, and reset times are recorded. The agreed demonstration fits the available slot.
- ☐ The kit is packed, owners know their roles, and the observation sheet is ready.

Checkpoint record: C01 · **Packet version:** ☐ · **Owner:** ☐ · **Review date:** ☐ · **Status:** [not reviewed / ready / needs revision] · **Evidence:** [rehearsal IDs and timings] · **Unmet checks:** ☐ · **Fix owner and deadline:** ☐. Keep status open until the checks are performed.

Reset and feedback checkpoint

Restore crossing one, four seats, two obols, and three Standing. Return every soul to the S01 to S12 supply order with zero refusals, then deal S01 to S05. Empty the wraith and delivery areas. Return residue slips to the unused component pool, with the draw queue, hand, and discard empty. Remove temporary effects and restore all three route slips. Keep collected observation records separate from the reset game state.

After the showcase: Record how many demonstrations were attempted, which were completed or stopped, the most frequent rule question, one participant quote, and the observed choices that support the next change. Keep counts and quotations separate from interpretation. Update the decision register and backlog before expanding the prototype.

18 Playtests observations and decisions

No playtest results are supplied. The worked record demonstrates a calculation, not observed play. Separate actions, participant statements, and interpretation.

Completed test plan

Question: Do remembered effects and waiting consequences influence later departures?

Setup: Base six-crossing trial, fixed supply order, all routes open, wishes flavor-only, events off. Record the rules version. Start with section 6 resources and empty residue zones. Give the same explanation to each participant.

Opening instruction: “Try to complete six crossings. The boat holds four seats. Quotas are due after crossings three and six. Inspect the visible cards and routes, then choose a departure.” Provide the remaining rules in the same reference sheet for every test.

Observe: Passengers, route, residue and target; resources before and after; refusal and wraith changes; timing; requests for help. Define timing start and end points. Ask: “What affected that choice?” Avoid suggesting mercy or profit as the expected answer.

Worked record, not a result: Crossing 1; passengers S01/S02/S05; route Asphodel; residue none; seats 4; obols 2 to 2; Standing 3 to 6; S03/S04 reach refusal 1. Time, participant explanation, and interventions: unmeasured.

Paired route comparison

Proposed comparison: Condition A allows Asphodel only. Condition B uses the base three-route table. Hold the soul supply, resources, quotas, residue rules, and explanation constant. This compares the contribution of route choice, not the relative balance of the three routes in isolation. If participants try both, alternate which condition appears first and note learning effects. A small convenience test can identify confusion and candidate patterns; record its actual participant count before summarizing findings.

Copyable observation form

Session / participant code / date / facilitator: []

Rules version / condition / enabled modules / prior exposure: []

Hypothesis / setup held constant: []

Round	Boat and route	Residue and target	Resources before/after	Wait/wraith changes	Time	Help
[]	[]	[]	[]	[]	[]	[]

Exact quote: [] · **Observed action:** [] · **Interpretation:** []

Endpoint / crossing / reason: [] · **Continuation after failure:** [yes/no]

Unexpected rule question: [] · **Temporary ruling:** []

Copyable analysis and next-change record

Finding: [specific observation] · **Count:** [number/eligible opportunities] · **Participant coverage:** [number/participants] · **Evidence:** [session and crossing IDs]

Alternative explanation: [] · **Decision affected:** [D ID]

One proposed change: [] · **Expected effect:** [] · **Next setup:** []

Report route selections as counts with their denominator, and completion as completed runs out of attempted runs. Keep unfinished sessions and diagnostic continuations identifiable. Leave all fields blank until measured; do not turn a participant's route or fare choice into a moral score.

19 Optional mechanics and extension rules

TRIAL extensions: Every module below is off in the basic six-crossing trial. Each is a complete small experiment. Activate one module at a time unless a combination is explicitly specified. A list of possible systems is not a recommendation to implement all of them.

Write the active module ID on the test sheet. Its stated exceptions replace the corresponding base rule; all other rules remain in force. If two modules modify the same timing, payment, card, or destination, agree their order before testing the combination. Final-game values and fiction remain team decisions.

M01 Destination wishes

Purpose: Make a soul's requested destination affect the load. At setup, give S03 and S09 an Elysium request, S05, S06 and S07 an Asphodel request, and S04 and S08 a Tartarus request. Other souls have no route request. Relationship wishes remain separate.

Soft-request trial: All routes remain legal. At Arrive, gain one extra Standing if at least one delivered soul reached its requested destination, once per boat. A mismatch changes only its recorded story outcome. No extra loss applies. Example: Merchant and Messenger arriving at Elysium yield one total request bonus, not two.

Alternative strict-request trial: Replace the bonus rule. A soul with a route request may board only if the boat goes there. Souls without one remain unrestricted. If no affordable route can take a requested soul, it waits and decays normally. Do not enable both variants.

TEAM DECISION: Are wishes requests, binding consent, judgments, or negotiable desires? Which mismatches should affect memories rather than a numerical reward? Test whether soft rewards make one destination too attractive and whether strict requests produce forced waiting.

M02 Paid and event access

Purpose: Test temporary openings with an affordable fallback. Asphodel is always open. Elysium opens on crossings two and five; Tartarus opens on three and six. Display this full schedule at setup.

During Load, a player may buy a one-use permit for a closed selected route for two banked obols. Pay this permit and any ordinary route toll together when confirming. A naturally open route needs no permit. The permit applies to the whole boat, is consumed immediately, and cannot be saved, sold, transferred, or refunded after confirmation. Normal pressure and arrival rewards remain.

Example: On crossing one, Elysium would cost two for permission plus one ordinary toll. A bank of two cannot afford it. Asphodel remains available for zero. On crossing two, Elysium needs only its ordinary one-obol toll.

A failure does not restore payment. Openings close after that crossing's Cleanup. Do not combine this module with E03's discount in the first comparison. **TEAM DECISION:** Who grants passage, whether fees apply per boat or passenger, and whether openings follow a calendar or events.

M03 Destination changes residue

Purpose: Test whether arrival location changes the remembered history. Only S09 and S10 change their usual R01 reward in this module. Other souls, including linked pairs, keep their printed residue.

Destination and new type	Exact effect when later played
Elysium R07 Preserved Memory	Grant 2 protection. During Cleanup put this played card at the bottom of the draw queue instead of discard
Asphodel R08 Shared Memory	Name up to two different waiting souls and prevent each one's normal refusal this crossing; extra separation still applies
Tartarus R09 Reckoning	Grant 3 protection now and place one obligation token for the next crossing

All three cost one Standing and use the ordinary one-card play limit. If R07 is not played, discard it normally. R08 may target fewer than two souls when fewer exist, including none. Each R09 token adds one pressure on the next crossing, then expires after Cross whether survived or failed. Protection can offset that pressure. A token created on crossing six appears as an unresolved obligation in the final history; it does not extend the trial.

TEAM DECISION: Should destination transform every memory, a few special souls, or only narrative text? The trial's narrow mapping limits the content required to answer that question.

M04 Appeasing a wraith

Purpose: Test a recovery action. After Recall and before Load, once per crossing, pay two Standing to move one existing wraith to a Released area. Remove its pressure contribution immediately. This uses no boat seat and produces no fare, Standing reward, or residue.

The payment must be affordable before any arrival. Newly transformed wraiths can be targeted only on a later crossing. If no active wraith exists, the action is unavailable. Record the original soul and release crossing; do not erase its waiting history.

Example: With three Standing and two wraiths, appease one. Standing becomes one and one wraith remains. A subsequent free Asphodel crossing has two pressure before protection, so recovery does not automatically make the voyage safe.

TEAM DECISION: Is release a ritual, restitution, memory, or delivery? Should the cost be a resource, a seat, or a specific relationship? Test whether appeasement is a meaningful choice or routine maintenance.

M05 Archiving or forgetting

Purpose: Test deck clutter and the meaning of letting go. After a successfully paid Quota step, or the skipped Quota step on other crossings, once per run, choose one residue instance from the draw queue or discard. Put it in an Archive and gain two Standing. A hand or committed card is not eligible. Preserve the remaining queue order and the delivered soul's ledger entry.

Reversible trial: On a later crossing, after Recall and before Load, the player may pay two Standing once to return that instance to the bottom of the queue. It cannot be drawn or played immediately. Retrieval gives no reward and does not restore the once-per-run archive action.

Alternative permanent trial: Omit retrieval entirely. Do not switch variants during a run. No eligible card means the action waits unused. Since archiving occurs after arrival and quota, it cannot rescue a failed crossing or an unpaid quota.

TEAM DECISION: Is the card merely inactive, or is a memory truly lost? Keep the historical name visible under either interpretation unless the team deliberately chooses otherwise.

M06 Quota debt and escalation

Debt trial: At the crossing-three quota only, if the bank is below three, pay all available obols and record the missing amount plus one as debt. The run continues. That full debt is due after crossing-four arrival, before Decay. If it cannot be paid, end the run. Crossing six still requires three obols in full; no extension beyond the trial is allowed.

Example: Having one obol at crossing three pays one and creates three debt: two missing plus one surcharge. Arrival income on crossing four can repay it. Debt never removes Standing and cannot be repaid with residue.

Alternative escalation trial: Keep immediate quota failure, but change the two announced quotas to three and four. Do not use debt in the same first test. This isolates the effect of the rising requirement.

TEAM DECISION: Should Hades create a survival deadline, an obligation that can be negotiated, or an endless duty? Choose the consequence of missing a quota before adding a long campaign.

M07 Boat development and supplies

Capacity trial: At the start of crossing four, before refill, offer one permanent extra seat for three banked obols. Buying it makes capacity five for crossings four to six. Declining removes the offer for this run. Capacity never changes during a locked crossing. Keep printed two-seat conditions unchanged.

Alternative supplies trial: Keep capacity four. During Load, permit one purchase of a one-crossing ward for one obol. It grants one protection, adds to residue and aboard protection, and expires after Cross. It is paid at confirmation, cannot be stored, and has no refund on failure.

These are separate tests because both spend money on crossing safety. Neither is active in the basic rules. **TEAM DECISION:** Does progression expand power, add lateral options, or reveal more situations? The report defers changing capacity; adding upgrades is a deliberate scope change. [R, pp. 2 to 3]

M08 River uncertainty

Purpose: Test hidden resolution only after visible events are understandable. Before the run, show the four possible event rules, shuffle those cards once, and conceal their order. Draw one after Load is locked on each of crossings one to four. Do not recycle the event pile. Crossings five and six have no event.

Use E01, E02 and E04 from section 11. Replace E03 with **Late Invitation:** on a successful Elysium arrival, refund the one ordinary route-toll obol paid that crossing; otherwise no effect. No other payment is refunded. This replaces a pre-departure discount that could not sensibly operate after commitment.

Event pressure is applied before protection. There is no reactive residue play, passenger swap, or rerouting. Show a pressure range before confirmation, not a guaranteed total. Keep soul rewards visible.

TEAM DECISION: Hidden draw, current-event preview, or future-event preview? Record whether surprise creates anticipation, confusion, or choices with no plausible counterplay. Do not combine hidden events with hidden soul rewards in the first test.

M09 Uncertain soul memories

Purpose: Test uncertainty with a disclosed possibility range. Keep every statistic except S03's residue visible. At setup, randomly assign S03 either R02 or R03, with one of each equally available before the assignment. Conceal the result; print both possibilities on the soul card. Reveal and acquire the assigned card only on successful arrival.

S03's seats, fare, Standing, and eligibility never change. If it becomes a wraith or the crossing fails, it grants no residue and need not reveal. Keep river events off for this comparison.

TEAM DECISION: What signal allows inference about hidden rewards? This trial measures reaction to a known uncertainty; it does not yet establish a meaningful inference system. A later version needs clues that correlate with outcomes and enough repeat examples to test them.

M10 Multiple stops in one crossing

Purpose: Compare itinerary planning with the single-destination loop. At Load, choose one or two different destinations in a fixed order and assign every passenger to exactly one stop. Each booked stop must have at least one assigned soul. All passengers board at the shore, with a combined maximum of four seats. No passengers join during the voyage.

Pay every ordinary route toll plus one extra obol for a second stop before departing. Payments cannot be financed by an earlier stop's fares. One residue may be committed for the entire crossing. All of its Cross effects, including protection and conflict cancellation, apply only to the first leg; any shore-decay prevention lasts until the final Decay step.

Resolve each leg separately: route pressure plus existing wraiths and aboard modifiers, minus eligible protection. Aboard effects consider everyone still on the boat, including souls assigned to a later stop. After surviving the leg, deliver only that stop's assigned souls and collect their rewards. Standing earned here can absorb a later leg's pressure. A Tartarus service payment occurs only when at least one assigned soul arrives there.

After the final stop, resolve one Quota, one Decay, and one Cleanup for the entire crossing. Linked souls receive joint residue only if delivered at the same stop. Partners both aboard but assigned different stops receive solo residue; neither is left on the shore, so no extra separation refusal applies. One partner aboard and one ashore still triggers the base separation rule.

If a later leg fails, keep completed earlier deliveries and payments in history; the run ends before remaining deliveries. No refund applies. New residue is never playable mid-voyage. Waiting souls age only once for the entire itinerary.

TEAM DECISION: Does the extra planning justify another pressure resolution? Test this module alone, with no events, conditional gates, destination variants, or changing capacity.

M11 Promises and commissions

Purpose: Add a declared commitment without a new currency. During Load, the player may accept one displayed commission for that crossing. For the trial, the offer exists only when a linked pair is on the shore: deliver both members together on this crossing. Pay no deposit.

Successful joint arrival grants one extra obol, once. If the run survives but the promise is unmet, the next crossing permits no residue play. Place a visible lock token; remove it after that next crossing's Cross step. Cards can still be drawn and discarded while locked. Record fulfillment immediately on joint arrival and preserve it through any later quota failure. A terminal failure before fulfillment records a broken commission but causes no extra playable turn.

A player may decline with no penalty. One accepted promise cannot be changed after confirmation. No offer exists if no linked pair is available; select the lowest-ID pair if two are available. This is a deterministic commissioning rule, not a statement that the ancient gods used these terms.

TEAM DECISION: Are promises made to souls, Hades, Persephone, or the river? Should they encourage a new tradeoff rather than pay for something the player would already do?

M12 NPC encounters and transactions

Purpose: Test a brief shore conversation with an explicit mechanical cost. On crossing two, after Recall, an invented underworld clerk offers one of two actions: pay one obol to prevent one chosen waiting soul's normal refusal this crossing, or decline. The offer expires when Load is confirmed.

The payment is included in the confirmation total. The target must remain ashore; changing the load invalidates the offer until another legal target is selected or the service is removed. The clerk does not sell capacity, reveal hidden outcomes, or alter quota. The protection duplicates normal-decay prevention rather than stacking extra refusal removal.

Copyable encounter: Character [] · Offer trigger [] · Choices [] · Cost and payer [] · Target [] · Confirmation timing [] · Consequence [] · Expiry [] · Repeat limit [] · Narrative line [] · Test question [].

TEAM DECISION: Do NPCs belong inside the short shore phase, or in a separate hub? A hub would require its own navigation, inventory, timing, and return rules.

M13 Difficulty and ending variants

Learning trial: Change only starting Standing from three to five. Keep every other rule and the same soul order. **Pressure trial:** Change only starting Standing from three to two. Do not label either balanced. Compare timing, failure crossing, and explained choices using the same measurement sheet.

Endless-duty concept: Repeatable duty needs an explicit supply generator, quota schedule, deck-size policy, and voluntary stopping action. It is not enabled by recycling the twelve named souls as if they had never crossed. Use fresh soul instance IDs for new arrivals and keep prior history. Until those four rules are approved, the finite trial remains the executable version.

Narrative-ending concept: At a chosen boundary, show factual outcomes such as who travelled together, destinations visited, memories retained, and obligations outstanding. Avoid a total moral score unless the team deliberately wants one. A proposed ending title is a narrative label, not evidence of virtue.

Coverage and combination checklist

Mechanic family	Status and boundary
Capacity, passengers, composition, resources, residue, pressure, quota, waiting, wraiths	Fully specified for the base paper trial
Wishes, access, route residue, recovery, forgetting, debt, upgrades, supplies	Optional trial rules M01 to M07
River and reward uncertainty	Separate optional tests M08 and M09
Itineraries, commissions, NPC transactions	Separate optional tests M10 to M12
Difficulty, endings, metaprogression	M13 examples; final structure belongs to the team
Combat, direct steering, spatial navigation, crafting, equipment loot, multiplayer	Absent from this concept version; adding any requires a new decision and system sheet
Permanent death of Charon, soul death, mid-river rescue	Not implied by pressure failure; the fiction of failure is a team decision

Module combination template: Modules ☐ · Shared state ☐ · Overlapping timing ☐ · Priority rule ☐ · Stacking cap ☐ · Combined example ☐ · Failure example ☐ · Approved by ☐.

20 Greek myth as a design resource

Use ancient stories to generate constraints, requests, and exceptions. Each entry separates a source motif from an invented game rule. The locations in this workbook combine traditions into an adaptation; the team should choose its own coherent version rather than claim one universal ancient map.

Hermes and the arriving dead

Ancient passage: Hermes guides the suitors' spirits toward the asphodel meadow in Homer's *Odyssey* 24.1 to 14. [G1]

Game adaptation: Hermes can announce an approaching group and make relationships visible before boarding. In the deterministic trial, the whole supply is already known, so this is primarily presentation. To test limited forecasting later, hide the unused supply except its next two cards and reveal replacements as cards leave it. Refill still follows section 7; a preview does not add extra arrivals.

Example line: Two arrive together. Whether they leave together is yours to decide.

TEAM DECISION: Is Hermes a reliable guide, a source of partial information, or an occasional quest giver? Unreliable forecasts need discoverable signals rather than arbitrary deception.

Styx and promises

Ancient passage: Hesiod connects Styx water with divine oaths and punishment for gods who swear falsely, *Theogony* 775 to 806. [G2]

Game adaptation: Use M11's visible promise, payment, and temporary residue lock. The mechanic compresses a mythic idea into a crossing-scale consequence. It does not reproduce the source's divine penalties.

Example: An oath marker sits beside the two linked soul IDs. The departure preview states whether the selected load fulfills it. Breaking the promise is possible and legible.

TEAM DECISION: Can Charon bind himself, or is he carrying someone else's oath? This affects the player's authority and the meaning of failure.

Forgetfulness and the value of memory

Ancient passage: In Plato's *Republic* 621a to b, souls reach the Plain of Oblivion and drink forgetful water before rebirth. The passage distinguishes the plain Lethe from the river Ameles. [G3]

Game adaptation: M05 turns memory removal into an explicit choice while retaining a record of the person. A permanent version can carry a stronger emotional cost; an archive can test deck management first.

Example line: The name will remain in the ledger. The voice need not remain in the boat.

TEAM DECISION: Is forgetting mercy, loss, or practical necessity? Do not make deck efficiency the only visible consequence if the fiction asks the player to care about memory.

Cerberus and the boundary of return

Ancient passage: Hesiod's gate hound welcomes entry but prevents escape, Theogony 767 to 774. [G2]

Game adaptation: Cerberus can represent the final arrival boundary without becoming a combat boss. In the base trial, the Load confirmation already locks decisions and arrival records are permanent. Introducing a separate reversible approach would add a decision and must define its price and timing.

Example encounter concept: A living visitor has permission to enter but lacks permission to leave. Charon's task concerns an exceptional return contract, not defeating the guardian.

TEAM DECISION: Does the boat only carry the dead onward, or can special passengers return? Return rules should not silently undo the consequences of ordinary delivery.

Judges and contested destinations

Ancient passage: Plato's Gorgias 523c to 524a describes judgment by Rhadamanthus and Aeacus, with Minos resolving doubtful cases, and routes toward the Isles of the Blessed and Tartarus. [G4]

Game adaptation: A soul may have an official assignment, a personal wish, and an unresolved appeal. Those are three different pieces of information, not a single goodness statistic.

Completed narrative example: Merchant requests Elysium; an order names Tartarus; a named witness is still waiting. The team can test whether Charon follows the order, waits for testimony, or chooses to defy it. The costs of appeal and defiance are intentionally unapproved. Use M01 alone for the first mechanical wishes test.

TEAM DECISION: Is Charon a carrier, guide, advocate, or judge? Resolve this before assigning mandatory destinations across the full catalogue.

Elysium Asphodel and Tartarus

Ancient passages: Odyssey 4.561 to 569 promises Menelaus Elysium through his connection by marriage to Zeus. Odyssey 24 places spirits in asphodel. Hesiod's Theogony 713 to 735 locates imprisoned Titans in Tartarus. [G5; G1; G2]

Game adaptation: Preserve meaningful differences among destinations without claiming that every ancient soul followed the same sorting rule. Section 5's preservation, belonging, and reckoning are proposed themes; its prices and pressures are game settings.

TEAM DECISION: Which ancient details support the chosen experience, which are changed, and which are omitted? Record the answer in an adaptation ledger rather than relying on a vague claim of accuracy.

Persephone and a visible calendar

Ancient passage: The Homeric Hymn to Demeter assigns Persephone one third of the year below and two thirds with her mother and the other gods, at lines 398 to 403 and 441 to 447. [G6]

Game adaptation: A visible schedule can open petitions or special passage. M02 offers a six-crossing access experiment. Its timing is invented and should not be described as a literal seasonal ratio.

Example concept: A petition must reach Persephone before a displayed departure date. Waiting for a linked passenger can therefore cost an opportunity.

TEAM DECISION: Is the calendar atmospheric, a route restriction, or the main run structure? Hades and Persephone need not have opposing policies unless the team chooses that characterization.

Orpheus and conditional exceptions

Ancient passage: Pseudo-Apollodorus, Library 1.3.2, describes Orpheus receiving conditional permission to recover Eurydice and losing her after looking back. [G7]

Game adaptation: An exceptional contract can make information itself tempting. For example, inspecting a sealed passenger's identity could break an explicitly stated condition. This is an encounter concept, not an active trial rule; the team must specify the information benefit and failure outcome before testing it.

TEAM DECISION: Use named mythic figures, original souls with similar dilemmas, or both? A literal cameo needs more careful treatment of its source than a broad motif.

Copyable adaptation ledger

Motif: [] · **Ancient work and passage:** [] · **Translation and link:** []

What the passage supports: [short factual statement]

What this game changes or invents: []

Player choice created: [] · **Rule or module:** [] · **Counterplay:** []

Narrative consequence: [] · **Team decision:** [] · **Approval status:** [].

21 Team worksheets and next decisions

Completed decision record

TRIAL record D03: Does choosing a destination improve the crossing? Compare the three always-open routes with a single Asphodel-only version. Keep supply, resources, and all other rules the same. Capture choice explanations, decision times, and quota outcomes. A temporary one-stop model makes the comparison possible. The final route model remains open.

Owner: [assign] · **Test date:** [assign] · **Evidence:** [not yet collected] · **Decision:** [open]

Reusable decision record

ID and question: [] · **Owner and contributors:** [] · **Decision needed by:** []

Options and tradeoffs: [] · **Temporary test setting:** []

Evidence required: [] · **Actual observation with count or quote:** []

Chosen answer and reason: [] · **Affected systems and cards:** []

What stays open: [] · **Revisit trigger:** [] · **Version introduced:** [].

Change log template

Version and date	Change	Reason or evidence	Affected IDs	Owner	Next check
0.1, 17 September 2026	Initial design workbook and provisional trial	Concept report and team brief; no playtest results	Base set and optional modules	[assign]	First paper run
0.2, 17 September 2026	Added coming-week paper showcase section and checkpoint	Project owner request U2	17A and C01	[assign]	Showcase readiness review
[version]	[change]	[note]	[IDs]	[name]	[test]

Content inventory template

Type and ID	Decision it adds	Draft text	Mechanics checked	Played	Team approved
Soul []	[]	[date]	[reviewer]	[test ID]	[date or open]
Residue []	[]	[date]	[reviewer]	[test ID]	[date or open]
Route []	[]	[date]	[reviewer]	[test ID]	[date or open]
Event []	[]	[date]	[reviewer]	[test ID]	[date or open]

The next team meeting

1. Name the primary player experience and the temporary trial objective.
2. Choose whether the first run uses three routes or a single route for comparison.
3. Assign facilitator, player, and recorder roles, combining roles if necessary.
4. Read one linked-pair example and one failure example aloud to check shared understanding.
5. Run the trial without adding optional modules during play.
6. Record unresolved rulings, then choose the next single change from the evidence.

Parking area: Idea [] · Why it matters [] · Dependency [] · Earliest useful test []. An idea placed here is preserved, not scheduled or approved.

22 Sources and provenance

Project source

R: The Ferryman Concept Report, Team F2P, CSS481 Game Development, four pages. Source file: C:/Users/purin/Downloads/The_Ferryman_Concept_Report.pdf. File modification time: 16 September 2026, 22:04:19, Asia/Bangkok. Embedded PDF creation date: 13 September 2026, 14:52:56 UTC.

The source is not inside an available Git repository, so its last commit date and freshness relative to a results commit could not be established. It is treated as the current concept because the project owner supplied it as such. No playtest results accompanied it. Source claims about legibility, balance, or decision quality are therefore design intentions, not measured findings.

U1: Project-owner direction in this conversation, 16 September 2026: explore different underworld destinations with prices or event access; provide exhaustive mechanics, completed examples, reusable team templates, and a quick summary. Major design decisions remain with the team.

U2: Project-owner direction in this conversation, 17 September 2026: add a section and checkpoint for a paper prototype showcase in the coming week. The exact showcase date and demo duration were not supplied.

Ancient texts

The links below host translations of primary ancient texts. They support the limited motifs cited in section 20. Trial costs, rewards, timing, fictional soul stories, and the three-route network are authored game adaptations.

G1: Homer, Odyssey 24.1 to 18. A. T. Murray translation. [Odyssey Book 24](#).

G2: Hesiod, Theogony 713 to 735, 767 to 774, and 775 to 806. H. G. Evelyn-White translation. [Theogony](#).

G3: Plato, Republic 621a to b. Paul Shorey translation. [Republic](#).

G4: Plato, Gorgias 523c to 524a. W. R. M. Lamb translation. [Gorgias](#).

G5: Homer, Odyssey 4.561 to 569. Samuel Butler translation. [Odyssey Book 4](#).

G6: Homeric Hymn 2 to Demeter, lines 398 to 403 and 441 to 447. H. G. Evelyn-White translation. [Homeric Hymns 1 to 3](#).

G7: Pseudo-Apollodorus, Library 1.3.2. J. G. Frazer translation. [Library Book 1](#).

How to record future evidence

For a project claim, name the rules version, test ID, number of participants or runs, observed count, and location of the record. Keep participant statements separate from interpretation. Recheck dated rules and results before using them to justify a change.

Example evidence sentence template: In [count] of [total] runs using [version], players [observed action]. The corresponding records are [file and row/page]. This suggests [limited interpretation]; the next test will examine [remaining question].